THE WORLD ISLANDS: PROJECT POST-MORTEM

A completed reclamation phase followed by a delayed island build-out

Incident summary

Dubai planned about 300 artificial islands arranged as a world map. Reclamation finished in January 2008, but most planned homes and resorts were never developed.

Incident timeline

2003 – Construction began
Jan 2008 – Reclamation complete
2008–09 – Financial crisis
Nov 2009 – $26B standstill sought*
2019 – 70% sold; 33 handed over
2021 – Anantara opened
Apr 2026 – Resort closed



Impact analysis

- Schedule: Reclamation met its 2008 target; wider development was delayed.
- Scope: Most islands remained undeveloped.
- Operations: Marine logistics and off-grid utilities made resorts costly to run.

Lessons learned

- Plan utilities and access with the main build.
- Prepare for financial downturns.
- Consider long-term operating costs.
- Define owner and developer responsibilities early.

Root cause

- Financial crisis reduced investor confidence and access to funding.
- Islands were sold without standard utility connections.
- Offshore transport and independent utilities raised costs.

Detection & response

Detected: Sales and construction slowed after 2008–09; operating sites exposed utility and transport difficulties.
Response: Developers arranged their own power, water, sewage, and boat transport.

Corrective actions

- Agree utility and access responsibilities before handover.
- Check buyers' funding and readiness.
- Explore shared services where practical.
- Monitor channels and shoreline conditions.

* Dubai World's standstill request covered about $26B in wider group debt, not debt specific to The World Islands.

Sources: ESA (2008) • IMF (2009) • Gulf News (2019) • The National (2012, 2026)